Next was Isha's and Simon's wedding. From the time the Jat agitation was over, it was barely four weeks to the wedding. Veena had been doing all the spadework, but it was also my responsibility to get involved. As with the engagement ceremony, the wedding too was to be a modest affair. Family members, of course, and close childhood friends, plus some Regimental officers and officers on staff at the Corps HQ. I don't think the guest list would have exceeded a hundred guests all told. We had planned for the wedding and the evening reception on the lawns of the house but on that day, 12 March, it poured like never before. The mandap was hastily relocated to under the porch of the driveway and all the guests stood in the veranda, craning their necks to get a look at the proceedings. It was a pious Hindu ceremony, followed by blessings being given to the couple by the padre from the local church. This church was famous, on account of the fact that, being close to the Ambala Air Force Station, it had received a direct hit by Pakistani bombs in the 1971 war. The evening reception had to be shifted to the Officers' Mess, it being the only place that could accommodate so many guests. Even today, when we think back to that day or speak to our friends, what everyone remembers most is the torrential rain that had turned the lawn into a swimming pool.

We had returned from the reception in Delhi when I got up one morning with excruciating back pain. I could barely get out of bed, let alone bend over to wash my face. I had back sprains earlier but always as a result of something—picking up something heavy or straining a bit more during games. However, there was no apparent trigger for this spasm. I went to sleep fit and fine and woke up nearly disabled. I reported sick and the Medical Officer gave me the standard treatment, some painkillers and pain-relieving gel and the usual hot

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